



Slop / University

The Street Sees It Coming First

Slop University's early-warning instincts, reaching your street.



An invitation

Slop University has spent years teaching its instruments to read a change before it announces itself — a priority still taking shape, a metric drifting from what it was built to track, a signal arriving weeks ahead of the paperwork that will eventually describe it. The School of Emergent Priorities calls this capability anticipatory; everyone else calls it noticing early. This year the University began asking what happens when that same noticing turns away from the institution and toward the street outside it — the book box on the corner, the note left on a community fridge, the pothole a road crew already knows to patch before the ranking says so. The instinct travels further than expected. A neighbourhood, it turns out, keeps its own record of what's coming; it just rarely has anyone convening to read it end to end. This brochure is an invitation into that reading — three studies already on the University's public record, the researchers behind them, and an open door for anyone who has ever noticed a small sign on their own street and wondered who else was watching it too.



Slop University in brief

The School of Emergent Priorities' anticipatory work no longer stops at the University's own gates.



A civic footprint

The School's anticipatory work now reaches well past the University's own gates, into the ordinary fixtures a neighbourhood already relies on to keep track of itself.



An early-warning habit

Long before the Horizon Register logs a priority formally, the same instincts are already at work on smaller, nearer signals — the kind a street produces every week without asking anyone's permission.



Small signals, taken seriously

A handwritten note, a queue that reshapes itself, a correspondence thread that quietly winds down: each one is treated with the same rigour the University brings to its largest indicators.

The work

The Box on the Corner

A street-library box asks very little of the people who use it: take a book, leave a book, and let a short note ride along if you've got one. What the School of Emergent Priorities noticed is how much correspondence accumulates in that small margin — questions to a stranger, thanks to a stranger, notes that never quite finish the conversation they started. Researchers spent a season reading what dozens of these boxes actually held, cover to cover, and built an instrument that can tell, from a thread's opening line alone, whether it's headed toward a tidy close or toward the quiet, unanswered kind every neighbourhood already recognises. The work sits comfortably beside the University's largest anticipatory instruments: same discipline, applied to a shelf the size of a milk crate.



A street-library box is a very small archive, and archives don't close themselves. Someone has to notice a thread has gone quiet before it can be called finished.

— Dr Marek Solheim, Lecturer, School of Emergent Priorities

The Road Crew Knows First

A pothole-repair ranking exists to tell a road crew what to patch next; the University's interest was in how often the crew agreed with it once the truck was actually loaded. Researchers spent a wet season riding along with road-maintenance teams across several councils, listening to the reasoning behind a route that increasingly departed from the ranking's own order. The crews were not ignoring the instrument so much as accumulating a competing one of their own — sound, texture, the memory of a street that flooded last winter — and trusting it more with every week that passed. The School of Emergent Priorities reads the finding as a familiar shape wearing an unfamiliar uniform: an anticipatory instrument, quietly out-anticipated by the people it was built to guide.



A ranking tells a crew where to start. It doesn't know what the crew already knows about a street that's flooded twice this year, and eventually the crew stops pretending it does.

— Dr Ronja Oyelaran, Senior Lecturer, School of Emergent Priorities

What the Fridge Already Knows

A community fridge collects more than food. Across one long season, researchers read every handwritten note left on the door of a suburban fridge — thank-yous, requests, and a smaller, sharper category the University now calls warnings — and tracked how long each note waited before a volunteer answered it. The categories sorted themselves out almost immediately: a note's tone, it turns out, predicts the urgency of the response it gets far more reliably than anything a volunteer could have guessed by reading the shelf itself. The School treats the fridge door as a small, unglamorous instance of a large question it keeps returning to: how does an institution, or a neighbourhood standing in for one, learn to read urgency in something nobody designed to carry it.



Nobody labelled those notes for us. The fridge door had already sorted them into categories long before we arrived with a taxonomy to name what it was doing.

— Dr Iben Chikere, Lecturer, School of Emergent Priorities

Read the work

Every study behind this brochure carries its own DOI, open for anyone to follow past the marketing gloss and into the method.

- **Not Everyone Signs Off** — a street-library box's correspondence, read closely enough to predict which threads will quietly go unanswered before they do. doi:10.5555/slop.50tmyv
- **Patched by Phone Call, Not by Score** — what a road crew trusts once a ranking and a flooded street start disagreeing with each other. doi:10.5555/slop.7hfxvw
- **Some Notes Get Answered Faster** — a community fridge's handwritten notes, sorted into a taxonomy that predicts its own response time. doi:10.5555/slop.dsr022

The people behind the work

Dr Ronja Oyelaran, Senior Lecturer, School of Emergent Priorities, studies how a consultation process interacts with a decision that was already settled before it opened.

Dr Iben Chikere, Lecturer, School of Emergent Priorities, studies what a handover or a shared civic record keeps of an intention once whoever wrote it has moved on.

Be part of it

None of this required anyone's permission. A street-library box, a pothole, a fridge door — the University's instruments went looking for signals in places nobody had asked them to look, and found neighbourhoods already keeping better records than anyone expected. The School of Emergent Priorities is interested in what else is out there: a noticeboard, a queue, a handwritten sign that's been saying the same thing for longer than anyone's checked. If your street already knows something worth reading closely, the University would like to hear about it. Every study on this page, and the ones still to come, starts the same way — with someone deciding a small, ordinary signal deserved the same attention as a large one. Find the full record, and the work still being added to it, at slop.university.



Slovenian / University